

A JOURNEY BACK TO SILENCE

EIGHT PASSAGES FROM NOISE TO STILLNESS

Written by Sabino Pereira

Companion music by Reira Bin

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Dedication

For those who are tired.

May this journey remind you that silence is not emptiness.

Sometimes, it is where we finally find ourselves.

A Note to the Reader

This is a work of reflective literary non-fiction. It offers companionship and questions, not medical or psychological advice. If silence brings forward distress that feels difficult to carry alone, seeking support is an act of care, not a failure of stillness.

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After the Journey

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Before the Journey

The world did not become loud all at once. It happened gradually: a message that needed an answer, a task that could not wait, a screen carried from one room to another, a thought interrupted before it had time to finish. Eventually, noise stopped being something around us and became something we carried.

We learnt to wake already thinking about what had not been done. We learnt to rest while feeling guilty for resting. We filled quiet moments with information, conversation, entertainment or worry. Even when the room was silent, the mind continued speaking.

Not all noise can be measured in sound. Some of it arrives as expectation. Some of it is the pressure to remain available, the habit of explaining ourselves, the fear that pausing will make us fall behind. There is the noise of other people's opinions and the subtler noise of our own rehearsals: what we should have said, what might happen next, what still needs to be solved.

This book is not an argument against modern life. It does not ask you to disappear, abandon responsibility or build a world without sound. It is simply an invitation to notice what has become difficult to hear: your thoughts before they become explanations, your needs before they become exhaustion, and your life before it becomes another list of things to manage.

Silence is often mistaken for emptiness. Yet an empty room is not necessarily silent, and a busy street does not always prevent stillness. The silence explored here is an inner clearing: enough space to notice what is present without immediately turning it into a problem.

Sometimes that space feels peaceful. Sometimes it feels uncomfortable. At times it may reveal a question we have avoided or a tiredness we

have normalised. Silence does not create those truths. It gives them somewhere to be heard.

The journey follows eight passages, each sharing a title with a piece of music by Reira Bin. The book and album belong to the same landscape, but neither requires the other. You may read with the music, read without it, move through the passages in sequence or return to one when its title calls you back.

There is no correct pace. You do not need to complete a passage each day, turn reflection into another discipline or extract a lesson from every page. Move slowly. Pause when something reaches you. Leave a page unfinished if you need to.

This is not a journey towards becoming a quieter person.

It is a journey towards hearing yourself again.

Welcome back.

PART I

Leaving the Noise

The return begins before anything outward changes.

Passage One

The Tide's Quiet Return

The Arrival

Exhaustion does not always look dramatic. Sometimes it looks like sitting on the edge of the bed for longer than usual. It looks like opening the same app several times without knowing why, or answering “I’m fine” because explaining would require more energy than you have.

Nothing has collapsed. You are still replying, working, planning, remembering and carrying. From the outside, life may appear entirely normal. Yet somewhere beneath the movement, something has begun to pull away — not suddenly, but like the tide leaving the shore so gradually that you notice only when you look down and see how far the water has gone.

The Reflection

We tend to imagine losing ourselves as a dramatic event: a crisis, a breakdown, a moment when everything becomes impossible to ignore. More often, the distance grows quietly. We move a little further from what we need. We postpone rest. We become efficient at ignoring discomfort. We keep going without asking whether the direction still feels like ours.

There is nearly always something that appears more urgent than returning to ourselves: a deadline, a conversation, a responsibility, someone else's need. Then comes the next thing, and the next. Over time, we can become deeply familiar with the demands of our lives and strangely unfamiliar with the life taking place inside us.

We know what must be done, but not what we feel. We know who needs us, but not what we need. We know how to remain available, but not how to become present.

This distance is not proof that we have failed. Often, it is evidence that we adapted. In difficult seasons we become practical, narrow our attention and do what must be done. We promise ourselves that we will return later. Yet later can become a place we never reach.

The journey back begins when we stop treating our own absence as normal. It may begin with a recognition that is simple but unsettling: I am tired in a way sleep does not fix. I have been moving, but I no longer know what I am moving towards. My life is full, yet something in me feels unattended.

These thoughts do not demand an immediate reinvention. Awareness is not a command to abandon a job, a relationship or a responsibility. It is the first honest glance at the distance between the life we are managing and the self who is managing it.

A return can be very small: a few minutes without input, a walk without filling the air, a morning in which attention is not immediately handed to the world, or a moment of honesty before saying that everything is fine. None of this looks impressive. It may not feel like progress.

The tide returns differently. It reaches the shore, withdraws and comes back again. Perhaps we return to ourselves in the same way — not once, not perfectly, but repeatedly. Each return makes the shoreline a little more familiar.

What the Silence Reveals

Sometimes we are not afraid of slowing down. We are afraid of discovering how long we have been tired. We fear that if we stop, everything postponed will catch up with us.

Silence does not create the truth. It makes room for us to notice it. What we notice may eventually require care or change, but it does not always require an answer in the same moment. Sometimes the first kindness is simply acknowledgement.

A Quiet Question

When did you first begin to feel distant from yourself?

The Pause

You do not have to return all at once.

Passage Two

Before the Morning Speaks

The Arrival

There is a brief moment each morning that many of us barely notice. It exists before the first notification, before the first request and before yesterday resumes its argument with today.

For a few seconds, the morning belongs to no one. It belongs neither to work nor expectation, neither to what went wrong nor to what must be done. It belongs only to the simple fact that we have awakened.

Most days, we surrender that moment without realising its value. Our hands reach for a screen before they reach for the light. Our attention leaves the room before our feet touch the floor. The world enters before we have arrived.

The Reflection

Morning has become less of a beginning and more of a continuation. We wake carrying unfinished conversations, unanswered messages and worries that were waiting before we opened our eyes. Instead of entering the day, we resume it.

Perhaps that is why some mornings already feel heavy. The day has not yet demanded anything, but the mind never truly stopped working.

There is something precious about the first quiet minutes after waking. They are still untouched. Nothing has gone wrong. Nothing has been solved. The day has not yet decided which version of us it requires. For a moment, usefulness can wait.

Attention is one of the few things we can still offer intentionally. If the first act of every morning is to give it away, it is unsurprising that we spend the rest of the day trying to reclaim it.

Protecting the beginning of a day is not a productivity technique. It is not a challenge to master or another routine by which to judge ourselves. It is permission to arrive before the world does: to notice the light changing outside a window, to hear the first sounds of the street, to breathe without immediately turning that breath into preparation.

The world will still be there after a few minutes. Messages will remain. Responsibilities will not dissolve. The purpose of a quiet beginning is not to pretend otherwise; it is to meet those realities from a place that has not already been scattered.

Some mornings offer little choice. A child wakes, a shift begins early, illness interrupts sleep, or care cannot wait. Quiet should never become another privilege used to measure a good life. The invitation is smaller and more humane: notice whatever threshold exists. It may be a single breath before rising, the walk to a bus stop, the first sip of water or a moment in a parked car.

A threshold does not have to be long to be real. What matters is remembering that the day is not only something that happens to us. Even briefly, we can meet it.

What the Silence Reveals

The first voice we hear in the morning can colour the voices that follow. When urgency speaks first, the day begins at a run. When presence is allowed even a sentence, the day has somewhere quieter to return to.

A Quiet Question

Who — or what — speaks first in your mornings?

The Pause

*Before the world asks for your attention, remember that it was
yours first.*

Passage Three

Rooms Filled With Light

The Arrival

Some rooms change before anything inside them does. The furniture remains where it was. The walls hold the same marks. The objects on the table have not moved. Yet when the light enters differently, the whole room feels altered.

A curtain shifts. Dust becomes visible in the air. A corner that seemed ordinary begins to glow. Nothing new has arrived. We are simply able to see what was already there.

There are moments in life like this. The world does not change. Our attention does.

The Reflection

We often imagine peace as something we must find elsewhere: in a quieter place, a better season, a life with fewer problems or a room without interruption. Sometimes peace does require distance or change. But sometimes it begins not with escape, but with noticing.

The cup beside us. The warmth of water. The shape of afternoon light on a wall. The sound of someone moving in another room. The small evidence that life is taking place even when nothing remarkable is happening.

Noise trains attention towards the urgent. Light invites attention towards the present.

This does not mean pretending that everything is beautiful. Some rooms hold grief. Some windows face difficult days. Some mornings arrive after sleepless nights. Attention does not erase what hurts, but it

can make a little space around it — not enough to solve it, perhaps, but enough to breathe beside it.

We can become so focused on changing our lives that we forget to inhabit them. We wait for clarity before becoming present, for rest before slowing down, for peace before noticing what is gentle. Yet gentleness is rarely loud enough to interrupt us. It must be welcomed deliberately.

Light enters through whatever opening is available. Calm can do the same: through a few unclaimed minutes, music playing softly, a person who does not ask us to perform, or the decision to sit down before exhaustion makes that decision for us.

An ordinary room filled with light remains an ordinary room. Its power lies in being seen. Perhaps a meaningful life is not always one filled with extraordinary moments. Perhaps it is one in which ordinary moments are allowed to become visible.

There is a risk in turning attention into another demand: notice more, appreciate more, be grateful correctly. That is not the invitation. No one needs to romanticise every day. Some days are tedious; some are painful. The practice is only to resist overlooking all of them.

The journey back to silence is not solely about removing sound. It is also about recovering our ability to see what constant noise made invisible.

What the Silence Reveals

Beauty did not disappear when life became busy. It simply stopped competing for our attention. Quiet things rarely insist on being seen; they wait for us to become available to them.

A Quiet Question

What is already present in your life that hurry has made difficult to notice?

The Pause

Sometimes nothing needs to change before the light returns.

PART II

Listening Within

Quiet is not always empty, and listening is not always easy.

Passage Four

Echoes Between Waves

The Arrival

The sea repeats itself without ever becoming identical. One wave arrives, then another. The shoreline shifts. The light changes. The person watching changes too.

Memory behaves in much the same way. Certain thoughts return, altered slightly by the life we have lived since they first occurred. A conversation sounds different after ten years. A face appears with details we thought we had forgotten. A sentence we wish we had said arrives beside one we wish we had never spoken.

Like waves, these memories do not ask permission. They return, touch the shore of our attention and withdraw.

The Reflection

Many people approach silence with the hope that it will empty the mind. That expectation can make quiet feel like failure. We become still, and suddenly everything we tried not to think about begins speaking: old regrets, unfinished conversations, forgotten ambitions, people we forgave and people we never did.

Silence did not create these echoes. It removed enough noise for us to hear them.

Occupation can be useful, necessary and joyful. It can also become a form of protection. As long as something demands our attention, we do not have to ask what remains underneath it. Am I becoming someone I recognise? When did joy become another appointment? What am I carrying because I have never paused long enough to put it down?

Such questions can sound severe when written in a row. In life they rarely arrive as an interrogation. They surface obliquely: in a song, a dream, a familiar street or an unexpected silence after company has gone. An echo is not a verdict. It is evidence that something mattered.

Some echoes are invitations to repair. Others ask only to be acknowledged. A few belong to chapters that can never be rewritten. Listening does not guarantee closure, and closure is not always available. What listening can offer is a more honest relationship with the past.

We sometimes imagine that healing means forgetting. It may be gentler than that: remembering without allowing the memory to occupy the whole present; recognising a wave without being pulled beneath it; knowing that a former version of ourselves made choices with the understanding available at the time.

Compassion is not the same as excuse. We can admit harm, regret what happened and still refuse to build a permanent home inside remorse. We can honour what was lost without asking every future day to relive the loss.

There will always be echoes. To be human is to be shaped by what has touched us. The task is not to silence the past, but to hear it without surrendering the present.

Eventually, even the loudest wave returns to the sea. Perhaps some thoughts are trying to do the same. They are not asking to be held forever. They may be asking us to stop pretending they never arrived.

What the Silence Reveals

Not every memory returns because it wants to be relived. Some return because they can finally be met with the understanding that was unavailable when they were made.

A Quiet Question

Which thought keeps returning because it has never truly been heard?

The Pause

Let the echo arrive. You do not have to follow it everywhere.

Passage Five

Where the Ocean Waits

The Arrival

Standing before the sea, it becomes difficult to believe that life must always move at the speed we have accepted. The water advances and withdraws. The horizon remains where it is. Nothing appears anxious, yet nothing is entirely still.

The ocean does not offer a lesson in the way a teacher does. It offers scale. For a moment, the unfinished tasks in our minds are placed beside something older, wider and indifferent to urgency. They do not disappear. They become proportionate.

The Reflection

Some pressure comes from circumstance; some comes from the belief that every uncertainty must be resolved immediately. An unanswered message becomes a problem. A decision becomes an emergency. A period without visible progress begins to feel like failure.

Waiting is difficult because it refuses to provide the evidence we want. It asks us to remain in a life that has not yet explained itself. In response, we rehearse, predict and search for guarantees. We try to force tomorrow into today because not knowing feels too close to losing control.

Stillness can look like stagnation when we value only visible movement. Yet much of life develops beyond observation. Trust deepens through repeated, ordinary acts. Grief changes shape without announcing when it has done so. A skill grows through practice long before confidence catches up. A relationship reveals its character over seasons, not moments.

None of this means that waiting is always wise. Some situations require action, boundaries or departure. Patience should not be used to keep someone inside harm. The point is not to glorify delay; it is to recognise that urgency is not the only form of care.

There are questions that become clearer through effort and questions that become distorted by being asked too often. There are decisions improved by research and others that need a night in which no more information is gathered. Wisdom includes learning the difference.

Waiting can be active. It can mean preparing without panicking, tending what is ours while releasing what is not, and allowing an answer to mature instead of demanding that it appear fully formed. It can mean trusting that the absence of clarity is not proof that everything is falling apart.

The tide withdrawing from the shore appears to be leaving, yet withdrawal belongs to its return. Human lives do not follow the ocean's certainty, but the image can steady us. Not every quiet season is empty. Not every delay is rejection. Not every unresolved question is an emergency.

Peace may begin when we stop asking the present to contain the whole future.

What the Silence Reveals

Some answers become visible only after we stop chasing them. Others never arrive in the form we expected. Quiet helps us distinguish between an answer still forming and a certainty life may never offer.

A Quiet Question

What are you trying to force that might need time, space or a different kind of attention?

The Pause

You are allowed to live while the answer is still becoming clear.

Passage Six

The Weight of Silence

The Arrival

Not every silence feels peaceful. Some rooms become so quiet that our own breathing seems unfamiliar. A clock grows louder. The floor settles. A distant car passes, and suddenly there is nowhere obvious to hide from ourselves.

Many of us leave such moments as quickly as we can. A television is switched on. Music begins. A phone appears in the hand almost without thought. Anything to fill the space.

The silence itself has done nothing. It has only removed the distractions.

The Reflection

For a while, noise can protect us. We stay busy, answer messages, make plans and carry responsibilities. From the outside, life appears full. Inside, something waits.

Eventually there may come a moment when activity can no longer keep everything at a distance. This is the weight of silence — not because silence is heavy, but because it reveals what we have been carrying.

That may be grief that never had time to be mourned, disappointment renamed as indifference, fear expressed through control, loneliness hidden behind productivity, or a dream abandoned so gradually that we barely noticed it was gone. It may also be something less dramatic: boredom, restlessness or the simple unfamiliarity of being alone with our thoughts.

Quiet does not always lead to revelation. Sometimes nothing profound happens, and that is part of its honesty. But when something does rise, the first response need not be judgement.

The person standing in that quiet room has often done the best they could with what they knew. They adapted to difficult seasons. They kept moving when stopping did not feel possible. There is no shame in survival. The danger lies only in assuming that survival must remain a permanent way of living.

Recognition can feel painful because it interrupts the stories that kept us functioning: exhaustion is strength; constant busyness is purpose; being needed is the same as being known; getting through the day is the same as being present in it.

Silence offers no automatic cure for what it reveals. Some things need conversation. Some need practical change. Some deserve professional support, community, prayer, rest or time. Quiet is not a replacement for care. It is often the place where we recognise that care is needed.

There is courage in staying long enough to listen without demanding an immediate solution. What first feels unbearable may become nameable. What is nameable may become shareable. What is shared may no longer have to be carried in secrecy.

The silence may not become lighter. We may simply become less afraid of meeting ourselves there.

What the Silence Reveals

The parts of us we avoid are not always trying to overwhelm us. Sometimes they are asking, in the only way they know, to be met with attention and care.

A Quiet Question

What part of yourself have you been trying not to hear?

The Pause

Stay only as long as feels honest. Silence is an invitation, not a test.

PART III

Returning Differently

The world has not disappeared. The way we meet it can change.

Passage Seven

Where the Land Ends

The Arrival

There is a place where the land simply stops. The ground reaches its limit, and beyond it lies the horizon. Standing there, we cannot avoid the scale of things: the sea stretches farther than sight, and the sky refuses to reveal where it ends.

For a moment, certainty feels less necessary. The world is larger than our understanding, and somehow that can be comforting. Not everything needs to fit within our reach.

The Reflection

Control offers the promise of safety, but often asks more than we can afford to give. It asks us to carry tomorrow before today has finished, to solve problems that do not yet exist, and to believe that enough rehearsal can make uncertainty disappear.

We predict conversations, prepare for every possible reaction and hold ourselves responsible for outcomes shaped by other people, chance, timing and conditions beyond our view. Worry begins to feel like work. Because it is exhausting, we assume it must be useful.

There is freedom in recognising the edge of what we can control. This is not the freedom of indifference. It is the clearer boundary between responsibility and ownership.

We are responsible for our choices, words, actions, kindness and integrity. We can prepare carefully, apologise sincerely, make a considered decision and show up with courage. We are not the sole authors of what happens next.

Not every relationship can be saved by one person's effort. Not every dream arrives in the form imagined. Not every goodbye can be prevented. Not every question receives an answer. Accepting these limits is not defeat. It is a form of humility.

The distinction matters because false control consumes the energy needed for real responsibility. When we stop trying to govern every outcome, our hands become available for the work that is actually ours: the next honest conversation, the boundary that should have been named, the promise we can keep, the kindness possible today.

Faith is sometimes confused with certainty. It may be something quieter: the willingness to take the next step without demanding to see the whole road. For some, that faith is spiritual. For others, it is trust in relationship, process, time or the accumulated evidence that they have survived uncertainty before. In every form, it begins at the limit of guarantee.

The horizon cannot be reached by walking towards it, yet it gives direction. Mystery does not always oppose peace. Sometimes peace begins when we stop requiring life to reveal everything at once.

The edge of the land is not the end of the journey. It is where we stop believing that we must hold the whole world together. When that impossible burden is released, we can finally hold what truly belongs to us.

What the Silence Reveals

Some burdens grow heavy because we have mistaken proximity for ownership. We may care deeply about something without having the power — or the duty — to control its outcome.

A Quiet Question

What are you holding that was never yours to carry alone?

The Pause

Let the horizon remain a horizon. Take the step that is yours.

Passage Eight

After the Rain Leaves

The Arrival

Rain has a quiet way of changing the world after it leaves. Streets reflect the sky. The air feels clearer. Leaves hold small drops that catch the morning light.

The world has not become new. It has become visible again.

There is a stillness that belongs to the minutes after a storm. Not everything has been repaired. Branches may have fallen; puddles remain; journeys have been delayed. Yet the air no longer seems to be fighting itself.

People can know such moments too.

The Reflection

We often imagine transformation as a defining event: a single decision, a revelation, a life divided neatly into before and after. Real change is usually quieter. It appears in choices no one applauds: the pause before reacting, the conversation we no longer rehearse, the morning begun without immediate distraction, the afternoon in which rest is allowed without defence, the evening when we forgive ourselves for being human.

None of these moments seems extraordinary. Together, they can reshape a life.

This journey was never about becoming someone else. It was about hearing the person obscured by years of urgency, expectation and noise. That person was not lost. They were simply difficult to hear.

The world around us may remain as busy as it was before. Emails will arrive. Plans will change. People will misunderstand us. Some days will still hurt. Silence does not remove uncertainty; it changes the way we meet it.

A quiet strength grows when we no longer believe that everything deserves an immediate response, that worth must be proven through constant productivity or that exhaustion is evidence of purpose. This strength is not withdrawal. It allows us to participate without being consumed by participation.

We can answer without living in reaction. We can care without carrying everything. We can work without treating ourselves as machines. We can be present with another person because we have not abandoned our own inner life.

The destination was never silence itself. Permanent stillness would not be a life. The destination was a steadier way of moving through sound, demand, relationship and change — a quieter centre that does not vanish simply because the day becomes difficult.

The tide continues. Morning arrives. Rain falls again. Life offers no permanent calm, only moments in which we can practise returning.

To notice them. To inhabit them. To be grateful for them before they become memories.

Perhaps that is enough.

Perhaps it always was.

What the Silence Reveals

We do not need a silent world in order to live from a quieter place. The return becomes real when it travels with us into ordinary life.

A Quiet Question

As you leave these pages, what kind of presence do you hope to become?

The Pause

*Carry the silence with you. The world will be loud again; you
do not have to lose yourself inside it.*

After the Journey

At the end of a journey, there is a temptation to believe that we have arrived. Perhaps we never do. Perhaps life is less a destination than a practice of returning.

Returning to what matters when distraction pulls us away. Returning to kindness when frustration feels easier. Returning to hope when certainty disappears. Returning to ourselves when the world asks us to become everything except who we are.

You will leave this book and life will continue. There will be noisy mornings, unexpected losses, beautiful conversations, ordinary afternoons and evenings when the quiet feels distant again. That does not mean the journey has been undone. It means you are human.

The aim was never to become untouched by noise. A life of love, work, community and responsibility will make sound. People will need us, and we will need them. The question is whether all that sound must become an inner command.

Quiet can remain as a remembered place: not a room we keep perfectly undisturbed, but a path we learn to recognise. We know when we have wandered from it. We know the small signs of return — a breath that is not preparation, a boundary spoken without anger, a moment allowed to remain unfinished.

Whenever the noise becomes too much, remember this: the tide knows how to return. Morning begins again. The ocean can wait. Light looks for an opening. Rain eventually releases the sky.

And somewhere beneath the voices competing for your attention, there is still a quiet place within you. It is not always easy to reach. It may not feel peaceful every time. But it has not disappeared.

You can return slowly.

You can return imperfectly.

You can return as often as you need.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira is an independent creator building original worlds through books, music and meaningful experiences. Under SP, he writes reflective non-fiction and stories exploring identity, faith, healing, relationships and the quiet moments that shape us. Under RB — Reira Bin, he creates cinematic music designed to evoke emotion, memory and imagination.

A Journey Back to Silence brings those two practices together: words by Sabino Pereira and a companion instrumental album by Reira Bin.

Final Page

*This is not a journey towards becoming a quieter person. It is
a journey towards hearing yourself again.*

Sabino Pereira